How I Trumped Rudolf Steiner and Overcame the Tribulations of Illiteracy, One Snickers Bar at a Time

By Sufjan Stevens

There are some things you tell no one, secrets packed and folded away in the far reaches of your mind - admissions of athlete's foot, or a night spent in jail. These irreversible facts, like birth certificates and blood donor cards, we keep undercover . . . hidden in the closet, under the Ouija board and Christmas-tree stand. I'm a glutton for exhibitionism, so I'd like to reveal a dirty secret: I didn't learn to read until third grade.

INTRODUCTION

Why??? Until 3rd grade I was a product of the Waldorf system of education created by Rudolf Steiner. (whisper) a progressive education.

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Rudolf Steiner, an Austrian social theorist, developed an educational system that was holistic, noncompetitive, and emotionally balanced. There were no textbooks, only paint, clay, knitting needles, and sheep's wool. I don't recall a library or a science lab in our school. but the classrooms were decorated with satin drapes and paper lanterns. Every room was designed to imitate a tree house or a bear cave or an underground den.

Learning was measured by the students' creative whims -- beeswax one day, cotton string the next. There were no vocabulary exercises or math quizzes. The syllabus was hand drawn on the chalkboard. Sweeping rainbow illustrations of unicorns and magic owls and eavesdropping elves. The school did everything to blur all lines between fact and imagination, between art and science, between math and English, between student and teacher.

For some, the disregard for standards was galvanizing. My peers took up the violin, spoke French, mastered oil painting, weaving, and the classical guitar. But I was a slow learner, prone to daydreaming. I had trouble making

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friends, so I imagined them: Peter the ox, Dora the talking skeleton, Herb the dietician. I lived in a world of fantasy and make-believe where reading and writing were banned by laws of my own creation.

Years went by - preschool, kindergarten, first grade, second grade - the dreamy sweep of a Steiner childhood. I was shuffled from calligraphy class to recorder lessons. The choose-your-own-adventure of progressive schooling. It didn't matter that I was so far behind the other kids. I would catch up, the teachers said. I would come around someday. I would learn to read and write by the powers of the Maypole, the winter solstice, the constellations, and Orion's enchanted belt. For Waldorf teachers, the real process of learning was to be stewed and simmered in a slow cooker. We learned not by worksheets and chapter guides but by watching seedling trees grow from teacups, the passing of the seasons, Baroque music, folk songs, and Nordic mythology.

Truth be told, I wasn't learning anything. By the time I finished second grade, it was clear something was wrong. I still couldn't read or write. I had no friends. I had no

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ambitions. I was a Waldorf flunky. But by then it was too late. My parents' marriage began to crumble, They started watching daytime TV, ordered pizza, bleached their teeth, and shed their educational ideologies once and for all. Then they got divorced.

That summer, I went to live with my father, who had moved to a small logging town with a bait shop and a Methodist church; a quiet village where people spoke with a southern drawl and wore overalls and drove tractors to work at K-mart. My father apologized for everything - for Waldorf and recorder lessons. "It's time you became a man," he told me. "It's time you learned to read."

So I was transferred to a public school, a cinderblock prison camp with metal lockers and industrial carpeting and severe fluorescent lights. Computers, textbooks, worksheets, MEAP, SAT, PTA, all the formidable abbreviations of public schooling. I clawed at the classroom windows like a hamster in a glass cage, desperate for fresh air.

The other children - raised on hot dogs and homogenized

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milk - were pig-nosed, bucktoothed, bullies who spent their free time at the arcade downtown. But at least they could read. I couldn't even spell my own name, so I was beaten up at recess, punched behind the swings, left in a rumpled mess in the gravelly residue of the playground.

After the first week of school, I was forced to take a series of multiple-choice tests - reading comprehension, basic math, language arts - each of which I failed. That's when I was ordered to go to special ed. They sent me to a boxy trailer slumped behind the cafeteria with a stack of flash cards and a vocabulary book, highlighting useful, ordinary words that would help me navigate the everyday life of the working-class man. ***Apple pie. Toothpaste. Driver's license. Checkbook. Garbage can.*** I recognized the letters, but I couldn't piece them together into words. I was uninspired.

My English teacher, Mrs. Lubbers, pulled me aside and said, "What is wrong with you? Are you retarded?" At lunch, she unpacked her lunch on the table and made me identify each object: juice box, banana, salami sandwich, potato chips. Then she pointed out the obvious packaging. Everything was tagged with its name, in clear, concise

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advertising. She told me about the wonders of the industrial age, how every item of food is mass-produced and sold to the public with its nametag right on front: ***Hello. My name is _____.*** She called the grocery store a public library, a literary adventure, a reader's guide for the leaming-disabled.

MRS. LUBBERS: We are surrounded by words. It's impossible ***not*** to read in this day and age!

Mrs. Lubbers had devised a theory. Having been rescued from the liberal clutches of Rudolf Steiner, I was like a primate, a wild stallion or Frankenstein's monster. I only needed the brash brainwashing of civilization. A crash course in modem society, pop culture, Mickey Mouse, the Hardy Boys, Ronald McDonald. I needed the chlorinated conditioning of the modern world - television, GI Joe, Garfield and Cocoa Puffs. I wasn't dumb, she told me. I was just Old World, nineteenth century, under stimulated. The glorious product placement of the advertising age would certainly inspire me.

MRS. LUBBERS: Read the label and you will soon be

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channeling Garrison Keillor, Vincent Price, and Salman Rushdie.

The next day was payday, shopping day. I begged my father to take me to the local Super K, a commercial paradise, a library of information. When we got to the store, I kept my eyes open for the literature of the advertising world. ***Palmolive. Antibacterial. Tough on grease. Downy. Duracell. Aspirin. Scotch tape.*** These were mini-novels, rousing in me the desire to read. I started with a book of matches, inspecting the small print: ***Close cover before striking*** - a mysterious line of haiku. I sounded out the simple words on soup cans, toothpaste tubes, cracker boxes: ***Weight. Squeeze. Caution. Press. Warning.*** A simple glance at a box of Arm & Hammer baking soda beckoned the epic verse of warrior kings feuding with metal swords and battle-axes.

I perused the short story of the lip balm: "If irritation occurs, discontinue use." I marveled at the absence of verbs on the Vitamin C: ***one tablet, twice daily;*** and the captivating demands on the caps of bleach: ***push, turn, pull, pry.***

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Soon I was reading whole sentences, paragraphs, pages. I had triumphed over the educational armies of Rudolf Steiner and basked in the glories of commerce and capitalism, from which all knowledge thrives. I could finally read!

I took notes, made outlines, wrote ambitious dissertations on the flea circus, the Sharpie, Roe v. Wade, the hooded sweatshirt, Dance Camp, and how I heroically overcame the tribulations of illiteracy, one Snickers bar at a time.

I brought in a can of Campbell's tomato soup and read every word on the label, to prove it to the rest of the class: "In a four-quart pot combine one can of soup and one can of water. Simmer over low heat, stirring often. Serve. Enjoy."

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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